

ball! Then, where but at the Google Zeitgeist would you get info on what *kids* were (and are) looking for?

- Search reflects what's on peoples' minds. Not so what's in the news. There might much of a hullabaloo in the press about a certain piece of news, but if people don't end up searching for it on the Web, it doesn't really reflect the spirit of the times, does it?

And finally,

- Surprises! No prizes for guessing that "VAT" and "budget" would have been searched for a lot by Indians in the pre-tax month of March 2005, but would you expect that people were much more interested in *Aishwarya Rai* than in either of these pressing developments? Is that a sign of the times, or what?

4.9 Google Web Accelerator

(<http://webaccelerator.google.com/>)

This application has been designed to speed up your Internet connection. Google tells us that dialup users "may not see much of an improvement," and it's optimised for broadband connections. So how does it work? First, frequently-visited pages are stored on Google servers, so they can be dished up faster: there are dedicated servers for Google Web Accelerator. Then, some pages might be prefetched onto your computer in the anticipation that you'll visit them. And, Web data is compressed before it is sent to your computer.

When you download and install the app, it sits in your system tray, and you can start or stop it from there. In Preferences, you have the option of choosing dial-up, DSL, and so on. Now when Google says DSL, they mean speeds in the Mbps range, so if you're on "Indian Broadband," you're still best off selecting "Dial-up."

The big question: does it work? The simple answer: we tested it on an "Indian Broadband" connection—Sify, to be precise—and it seemed to improve speeds for popular sites such as BBC and CNN. This could have been psychological, though! And don't expect much of a speedup from pages like <http://home.ipact.nl/~user-name/>!

Even if you're on dial-up, download it and give it a try—you have nothing to lose except for a couple of minutes! After you've used it for a while, remember there's an option in the system tray menu that tells you how much time you've saved using the application. When you see that figure go into the hours, you know the app works.